



It's the game that wins: Irrespective of what happened in the final, the 62,000 fans at the Salt Lake Stadium should remember that football won. PTI

the offensive, but the host drew first blood. Against the run of play, Dimitri Petratos, Mohun Bagan's hero in last season's final (scoring both goals), shot from distance, but the attempt was saved by Mumbai goalkeeper Phurba Lachenpa, only for Jason Cummings to tap the ball in on the follow-up.

Mumbai's comeback began in the second half, with the equaliser arriving within eight minutes of the restart. Jorge Pereyra Diaz received Alberto Noguera's long ball, beat his marker, Manvir Singh, and squeezed it in from a narrow angle.

Antonio Lopez Habas, Mohun Bagan's head coach, would later reflect, "Normally, we are a team that continuously attacks and defends. But today, when we attacked, the defence lacked, and vice versa. This was a problem for us."

Bipin, who scored the winning goal against Mohun Bagan (then called ATK Mohun Bagan) in the ISL final three years ago, continued to be the Mariners' nemesis, converting a pullback from Jakub Vojtus to double Mumbai's tally.

Vojtus put the competition to bed in the second-half injury time when he scored his first goal for the Islanders, with Mumbai shattering the treble-winning hopes of Mohun Bagan, which won the Durand Cup and the Shield this season.

With the win, Mumbai became the most successful team in the league, with two Shields and as many ISL trophies. It was also sweet revenge for the side. "I think the key to success was because we were very down when we lost here [against Bagan] because we wanted to play in Asia. But our strength has been figuring out why we lost, and we just ensured it doesn't happen again," Petr Kratky, Mumbai's head coach, said.

Kratky's tactical masterpiece

Kratky stated that his team had been passive in the Shield decider but planned to be more aggressive in the ISL final. It was clear from the start that Mumbai City and he meant business. "If you watch the game, we were better in the first half. Yeah, we conceded a goal because Mohun Bagan is a quality team, but our approach today was totally different than two weeks ago, and the boys executed it to get rewarded," Kratky said. Mumbai deployed Rahul Bheke and Mehtab Singh as two full-backs to counter Mohun Bagan's wing play

in its 3-5-2 or 3-4-3 formation, with Manvir and Liston Colaco playing as wingbacks.

While in possession, Jayesh Rane and Noguera tried to find the overlapping runs of Vikram Partap Singh and Lallianzuala Chhangte. As Joni Kauko and Deepak Tangri of Mohun Bagan tried to close down Pereyra Diaz, Vikram kept barging into the box to find gaps in the Mariners' defence.

Close to the half-hour mark, Mumbai City almost got a penalty when Noguera's cross for Vikram in the Mohun Bagan box hit Hector Yuste's hand—an incident referee R. Venkatesh failed to spot.

When out of possession, Lalengmawia Ralte, who was adjudged Player of the Match in the final, worked as an additional defender in front of the back-four, while Thaer Krouma denied Petratos any space in the final third.

Petratos' first shot on target came from way outside the box, which led to Cummings beating Tiri to score on the follow-up. Kratky's substitutions were clinical too. Mumbai's high press, especially in temperatures over 36°C, posed a risk of cramps, and Diaz, Noguera, and Rane were all off before the last quarter. The three players who replaced them, Bipin, Vojtus, and Vinit Rai, made significant